



▲ **Gundestrup cauldron**

This huge silver bowl dates from between 150 and 1 BCE. It was found in Denmark, but its decoration is rich in Celtic symbolism: here, the god Cernunnos, worshipped by Celts in Gaul, is shown with antlers, cross-legged, while other panels depict bulls being sacrificed. Some scholars think that the cauldron may have been used in druidic rituals.

TALES OF THE DRUIDS

Celtic myth and magic

Originally spread across Europe, Celtic people were living only in Ireland, Scotland, Wales, Cornwall, and Brittany by the medieval period. The ancient Celts developed a rich collection of myth and magic, but as a largely oral society, it is only indirectly, through ancient Greek and Roman writings, and in tales recorded by medieval Christian scribes, that their traditions and culture have survived. There are no first-hand accounts written by the Celts themselves, so it is sometimes difficult to distinguish between their genuine beliefs and practices, what was misunderstood or added by those who recorded these, and what was part of Celtic mythology.

Druids

Historically, druids are likely to have been wise men, teachers, or priests, but they have sometimes been described as having magical powers. Their magic and beliefs are reported to have been rooted in nature, with druidic rites often held in sacred groves.

According to Roman writer Pliny the Elder, druids saw magical powers in white-juiced mistletoe, which they thought brought fertility. Pliny also claimed that druids sacrificed animals; he described the killing of two white bulls as part of a druid ceremony for gathering mistletoe. Roman writers, including Pliny and Julius Caesar, are the sources of most historical